Marian Anderson's Voice for Liberty:
Challenging a Revolution, Igniting a Reaction, and Reforming Civil Rights

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Process Paper

For this year's theme, our group sought a subject that resonated with our shared passion for music and the arts. As musicians ourselves, we wanted a project that reflected our creative interests and was both socially relevant and historically impactful. Guided by this goal, we came upon the story of Marian Anderson, a famous black opera singer. Her experience in overcoming racial prejudices was, in a way, the first domino to fall in a chain of events that triggered the Civil Rights Revolution of the 1960s. We chose the medium of performance to bring to life her conflict with the Daughters of the American Revolution and her pivotal concert on the steps of the Lincoln Memorial.

We started by looking at website articles and news reports regarding both Ms. Anderson's performance and especially the historical context that led up to it (e.g., the motivations of the DAR in rejecting her from Constitution Hall). Then we found a collection of primary source letters from within the National Archives written by the key players of this story: Eleanor Roosevelt and the president of the DAR. We were also able to gain insight into Marian Anderson's personal perspective through her autobiography, *My Lord, What a Morning*, and her personal scrapbooks archived at the University of Pennsylvania. To understand the reaction of the American public, we examined newspapers with different perspectives. We found articles from the black press, like the *Atlantic Daily World* and *New Detroit Tribune*, particularly convincing.

To create our performance, we first divided the historical event into 5 segments, making each of our 5 acts distinct yet coherent. We additionally inserted direct quotes from primary sources relevant to the story. We then did extra research into the speech patterns and fashion of Americans in the 1930s. We rewrote the script after each competition to address judges' comments.

Marian Anderson's story and the events that led to her concert were key moments in American history that highlighted the struggle between different philosophies of the American Revolution and the reform that resulted from that clash. Her experience with discrimination from the DAR, who believed in their own manufactured ideals of the American Revolution, such as racial purity, sparked the reaction of influential figures like Eleanor Roosevelt, but also the American public, both black and white, which ultimately inspired the Civil Rights Revolution and pushed the DAR to reform its racial policies.

When individuals and institutions respond to emerging revolutionary ideologies with timely, courageous action, as Eleanor Roosevelt did, they transform conflict into heartfelt, lasting reform that bridges the gap between outdated traditions and human progress. Ultimately, this story isn't just a conflict of race, but a larger question of how old ideologies should be used in the ever-changing present.

Annotated Bibliography

Primary Sources:

"5,000 See Mrs. Roosevelt Present Spingarn Medal: Marian Anderson Makes a Beautiful Response: Captures Richmond With Her Winning Personality; Leads Jubilee." [Newspaper unknown], July 2, 1939. Marian Anderson Papers, box 410, item 1. Colenda Digital Repositories, Penn Libraries, Philadelphia, PA. https://colenda.library.upenn.edu/catalog/81431-p3hm52n3j

This article, glued into Marian Anderson's scrapbook, tells the story of Anderson being awarded the Spingarn medal. We include this award in our last scene to show the significance of the award to Ms. Anderson and to the public.

Anderson, Marian. *My Lord, What a Morning: An Autobiography.* 1956.

This autobiography details her journey from a humble childhood to international fame, including her groundbreaking debut at the Metropolitan Opera. We used this source to gain insight into Marian Anderson's thoughts, and we quoted a passage directly in our performance.

Marian Anderson: The Lincoln Memorial Concert (excerpt). 1939. Preserved and reconstructed by the UCLA Film and Television Archive. National Film Preservation Foundation. https://www.filmpreservation.org/preserved-films/screening-room/marian-anderson-the-lincoln-memorial-concert-excerpt-1939.

This video provides raw footage of Marian Anderson singing "My Country, 'Tis of Thee" on the steps of the Lincoln Memorial in 1939. By observing her performance, we gained a deeper understanding of the event's atmosphere and used it to ensure our portrayal was historically accurate. Evonne, who portrays Marian Anderson, studied Anderson's style and tried to match it in the performance.

"Berkeley Life Member of DAR Quits Over Marian Anderson Snub." *The San Francisco Chronicle.* March 1, 1939. Newspapers.com

This statement from a newspaper in 1939 was directly quoted within our performance to highlight the multiple perspectives that different individuals held regarding the Marian Anderson conflict. The article explains how a high-ranking DAR member disagreed strongly with the DAR's decision.

Black, Ruby A. "DAR Refusal To Lease Hall to Negro Singer Brings First Lady's Resignation." *Corpus Christi Times*. March 1, 1939. Newspapers.com

This statement from a newspaper in 1939 was directly quoted within our performance to

highlight multiple perspectives and to situate the Marian Anderson story within its historical context, with the growing Nazi and fascist movements occurring all over the world.

Civic Concert Service, Inc. *The Civic Concert Association Presents Marian Anderson in Concert: Program*. Concert Program. c. 1930s–1940s. Marian Anderson Papers, box 410, item 1. Colenda Digital Repositories, Penn Libraries, Philadelphia, PA. https://colenda.library.upenn.edu/catalog/81431-p3hm52n3j
This page from Marian Anderson's scrapbook serves as a reference for us to look at the type of songs that Anderson performed and provides additional context regarding her standing in the entertainment world at that time.

"Criticism of D.A.R. Action Brings Reply That Society Conforms to District Laws." St. Cloud Times. 28 Feb. 1939.
This article highlights a critique that was made of the DAR and shows how important the idea of "heritage" is to the foundation. Overall, it was important for us to have a deeper understanding of why the DAR wanted to stick to their white performers-only policy outside of their idea of adhering to social norms.

"D.A.R. Refuses Auditorium to Hazel Scott; Constitution Hall for 'White Artists Only'." *New York Times.* Oct. 12, 1945. Accessed Apr. 28, 2026 https://www.nytimes.com/1945/10/12/archives/dar-refuses-auditorium-to-hazel-scott-constitution-hall-for-white.html
This article puts into perspective the reasoning that the DAR had in enacting the white artists-only policy, as they believed that it was in line with the "prevailing customs." They believed that through historical precedent, the idea of separate but equal was not meant to show the inferiority of any race. We used this article to understand Mrs. Roberts' position and based her character and comments on it.

"D.A.R. Vs. Marian Anderson." *Atlanta Daily World*. Feb. 27, 1939. Newspapers.com
This article was quoted directly within our performance to highlight the perspective of black individuals/the black press regarding Marian Anderson's rejection from Constitution Hall. Interestingly, this article makes a direct counter to the argument of racial purity cited by the DAR, as it emphasizes the involvement of the African American people in fighting for the American Revolution.

Daughters of the American Revolution. *The Constitution of the National Society of the Daughters of the American Revolution.* Article II. 1890. Accessed Feb. 28, 2026
We used this constitution in Act Two, where Mrs. Roberts explains to Susan why the DAR cannot book Marian Anderson in their Constitution Hall. We were able to infer why

the DAR made the decision that they did, and it helped us see the conflict from their perspective.

Daughters of the American Revolution. *DAR Marian Anderson Statement.* Date Accessed: 16 Apr. 2026.
We used this statement to show the reforms that the DAR made after the backlash they received from the American public. These reforms include an official statement of apology and the removal of the white performers-only policy, finally allowing Ms. Anderson to use Constitution Hall.

Delar, New York. Marian Anderson, Full-length Portrait, Standing, Facing Front, Wearing Evening Gown. Photograph. c. 1930–1940. From the Library of Congress, Prints and Photographs Division.
This photograph was used in our newspaper prop.

Forsythe, William. "'First Lady' Gives Medal to 'First Lady of Song.'" [Newspaper unknown], July 6, 1939.Marian Anderson Papers, box 410, item 1. Colenda Digital Repositories, Penn Libraries, Philadelphia, PA.
https://colenda.library.upenn.edu/catalog/81431-p3hm52n3j
This news article from one of Marian Anderson's scrapbooks discusses the importance of the fact that Marian Anderson was awarded the Spingarn Medal by the First Lady. The awarding of the medal shows that this historical event was also one that was deeply tied to politics as well.

"Gracious Lady." Magazine Article. c. 1939–1945. Marian Anderson Papers, Ms. Coll. 200, Box 410. Kislak Center for Special Collections, Rare Books and Manuscripts, University of Pennsylvania.https://colenda.library.upenn.edu/catalog/81431-p3hm52n3j
This magazine article from Marian Anderson's scrapbook discusses Marian Anderson's character and how she interacted with the rejection by the DAR and her iconic performance at the Lincoln Memorial on a personal level.

Horuk, Sol. *Letter to Mrs. H. M. Robert Jr. Regarding Rejection of Marian Anderson.* Letter. Accessed 16 Apr. 2026.
https://www.dar.org/sites/default/files/4A%2CB_PGII%20b130f4%20January%2027%2C%201939_Letter%20from%20Hurok%20to%20PG%20Robert%20with%20her%20reply.pdf
We cross-referenced this letter with the letter from Secretary Ickes to the DAR (Mrs. Robert) in order to make our own historical reconstruction of the kind of letter that Marian Anderson would have received from her management regarding her rejection.

"[Howard University, 1939: Howard University Committee to DC Board of Education] - Colenda Digital Repository." Upenn.edu, 2026, Accessed 18 Apr. 2026.
This document shows how important the Marian Anderson performance was to Howard University and the people of Washington DC as a whole. This document references the protests that were held at the Board of Education for Marian Anderson.

Ickes, Harold. *Letter to Mrs. Henry Robert Jr. regarding Marian Anderson.* Letter. Accessed 16 Apr. 2026.
https://www.dar.org/sites/default/files/5A%2CB_SCR_DAR%20Subject%20Files_Anderson%2C%20Marian_February%203%2C%201939%20Letter%20from%20PG%20Robert%20to%20Ickes%20%28reply%20to%20his%20January%2030th%20letter%29.jpg
This letter highlights how government powers (in this case, Secretary Ickes) proved themselves to be an ally in the fight for civil rights. Ickes was one of the first prominent figures to express outrage at the DAR.

John F. Kennedy Center for the Performing Arts. "Marian Anderson." Video. Accessed April 29, 2026. https://www.kennedy-center.org/video/center/other/2020/marian-anderson/.
Our very dear opera singer (Evonne) used this video as a reference to study Marian Anderson's vocal technique to emulate how she would have performed.

Lautier, Louis. "Lincoln Memorial Perfect Setting for Marian's Voice." [Newspaper unknown], April 10, 1939. In *Scrapbook, photographs, programs, clippings, 1937–1944*. Ms. Coll. 200, box 410, item 1. Marian Anderson Papers, Kislak Center for Special Collections, Rare Books and Manuscripts, University of Pennsylvania. https://colenda.library.upenn.edu/catalog/81431-p3hm52n3j
This page from Marian Anderson's scrapbook celebrates Anderson's talent and notes her performance as one that was highly deserved. We mentioned her talent and her fame in Act 1 in order to demonstrate how Miss Anderson was accepted without question in Europe.

Lawrence, David. "Washington Tribute." *New York Sun*, April 11, 1939. Reprinted in *Scrapbook, photographs, programs, clippings, 1937–1944*. Marian Anderson Papers, box 410, item 1. Colenda Digital Repositories, Penn Libraries, Philadelphia, PA. https://colenda.library.upenn.edu/catalog/81431-p3hm52n3j
This page from Marian Anderson's scrapbook showcases how the media and the public rallied behind Anderson, transforming the event into a national symbol of the struggle for civil rights.

Letter to Robert (President General). NAACP. April 15, 1939. Box 124, folder 6. DAR Archives, Daughters of the American Revolution, Washington, DC. https://www.dar.org/sites/default/files/29%20PG%20b124f6%20April%2015%2C%201939%20Letter%20from%20NAACP%20to%20PG%20Robert.jpg.
This letter showcases the immediate impacts that occurred after Marian Anderson's performance at the Lincoln Memorial and highlights the DAR's stubbornness in not changing the white performers only policy until decades later (making it meaningful that they even put out an apology).

"Maine D. A. R. in Fall Meeting at Saco Church Today." *Biddeford-Saco Journal*, Biddeford, ME, October 16, 1939.
This was a newspaper clipping that was used for our collage of newspapers. It discusses the separatist attitude that the DAR had regarding the trend of growing fascism and the mounting world war in Europe, urging the American public to stay away from Europe affairs. This is ironic because the DAR itself was accused of holding fascist ideologies for their racist actions.

Marian Anderson Citizens' Committee. *Poster for Protest against Board of Education and DAR*. Circular/Poster. 1939. Moorland-Spingarn Research Center, Howard University. https://dh.howard.edu/cgi/viewcontent.cgi?article=1015&context=og_circulars
This protest poster, created by the Marian Anderson Citizens' Committee, was used to spread word of Anderson's rejection from both Constitution Hall and Central High School and organize a movement on her behalf. This poster is key in highlighting the complexity of this event, showing the important role that the American public played in securing Marian Anderson the opportunity to perform at the Lincoln Memorial.

"Marian Anderson Gets Medal From First Lady: Singer Told Achievement Far Transcends Creed or Race." Associated Press. [Newspaper unknown], July 2, 1939. In *Scrapbook, photographs, programs, clippings, 1937–1944*. Marian Anderson Papers, box 410, item 1. Colenda Digital Repositories, Penn Libraries, Philadelphia, PA. https://colenda.library.upenn.edu/catalog/81431-p3hm52n3j
This page from Marian Anderson's scrapbook specifically details the awarding of the Spingarn medal to Marian Anderson by First Lady Eleanor Roosevelt, highlighting the importance of Anderson's role in the fight for civil rights and combating racial prejudices

Marian Anderson, Half-length Portrait, Standing, Facing Front, with Hands to Her Face. Photograph. c. 1940. Library of Congress, Prints and Photographs Division.
This photograph was used in our newspaper prop.

"Marian Anderson." Magazine Article. c. 1939–1945. Marian Anderson Papers, box 410, item 1. Colenda Digital Repositories, Penn Libraries, Philadelphia, PA. https://colenda.library.upenn.edu/catalog/81431-p3hm52n3j
This page from one of Marian Anderson's scrapbooks serves as a primary record of events and the shifts in public opinion surrounding Marian Anderson's concert at the Lincoln Memorial. By preserving press clippings, programs, and photographs from this era, the collection showcases how the media and the public rallied behind Anderson, transforming the event into a national symbol of the struggle for civil rights.

"Marian Anderson Mural Approved by First Lady." [Newspaper unknown], June 8, [1939?]. In Scrapbook, photographs, programs, clippings, 1937–1944. Marian Anderson Papers, box 410, item 1. Colenda Digital Repositories, Penn Libraries, Philadelphia, PA. https://colenda.library.upenn.edu/catalog/81431-p3hm52n3j
This page from Marian Anderson's scrapbook serves as a primary record of events and the shifts in public opinion surrounding Marian Anderson's concert at the Lincoln Memorial. By discussing the importance of the mural painted in Ms. Anderson's honor, this page details the extent of the impact that her story had in America in a tangible way.

Marian Anderson Singing. Photograph. c. 1935–1945. New York World-Telegram and the Sun Newspaper Photograph Collection, Library of Congress, Prints and Photographs Division.
This photograph was used in our newspaper prop.

Matthews, Ralph. "National Anthem Rings True for Easter Throng." [Newspaper unknown], April 10, 1939, p. 75. Marian Anderson Papers, box 410, item 1. Colenda Digital Repositories, Penn Libraries, Philadelphia, PA. https://colenda.library.upenn.edu/catalog/81431-p3hm52n3j
This page from a scrapbook serves as a primary record of events and the shifts in public opinion surrounding Marian Anderson's concert at the Lincoln Memorial. By preserving press clippings, programs, and photographs from this era, the collection showcases how the media and the public rallied behind Anderson, transforming the event into a national symbol of the struggle for civil rights.

"Mrs. Roosevelt - Marian Affair." The Orlando Sentinel. March 1, 1939. Newspapers.com
This quote was also directly quoted within our performance to show the mixed reactions that American citizens had towards the DAR and Eleanor Roosevelt's involvement in the Marian Anderson affair.

"National Society Daughters of the American Revolution Archives Marian Anderson Resource

Guide.” n.d. Accessed February 14, 2026. https://www.dar.org/sites/default/files/MarianAndersonResourceGuide.pdf.
This is a source from the Daughters of the American Revolution that showcases the amount of primary documents that they have regarding the Marian Anderson racial incident (many other primary sources come from this repository)

"National Society of DAR Drafts Resolutions Recently." *The Vicksburg Post,* Vicksburg, MS, May 28, 1939.
This article discusses the stand that the DAR took against the growing fascism in Europe, highly ironic because they themselves were accused of being fascist for rejecting Marian Anderson. This piece was important for our understanding of the DAR’s policies in a broader perspective.

"Negro Contralto Given High Honor: Marian Anderson Presented Spingarn Medal by Mrs. Franklin Roosevelt." *The Wichita Eagle*, Wichita, KS, July 3, 1939.
This newspaper article discusses how Marian Anderson was awarded the Spingarn Medal in July of 1939 by Eleanor Roosevelt. This is key in displaying the short-term impacts that Anderson’s performance had in demonstrating black excellence and propelling her story nationwide. This article was used for part of our newspaper prop.

“NSDAR Archives Marian Anderson Documents (January-April 1939).” 2025. Daughters of the American Revolution. January 24, 2025. https://www.dar.org/national-society/marian-anderson/nsdar-archives-marian-anderson-documents-january-april-1939.
This source contains a collection of letters archived by the DAR that were sent between individuals involved in the Marian Anderson controversy (e.g., Roosevelt’s resignation letter).

NSDAR Executive Committee Ruling. “*That the words "white artists only" be added to the leases for the use of Constitution Hall.*” March 23, 1932. Accessed 16 Apr. 2026. https://www.dar.org/sites/default/files/12aa%20PGII%20b130f2%201932%20Ruling%20and%20Statement%20prepared%20in%201940.pdf
This primary source shows the exact executive ruling that occurred for the addition of the whiter performers only policy to the lease rules for Constitution Hall. This ruling was referenced in the performance.

“Opera Stars Protest D.A.R. Ban on Marian Anderson.” The Detroit Tribune. Feb. 4, 1939. https://www.newspapers.com/article/the-detroit-tribune/198916409/
This newspaper article highlights the country-wide popularity of Anderson and her influence on the entertainment world, specifically in the world of classical singing. In

this, multiple influential voices vouch for Anderson's skill and question the racially motivated rejection of the DAR.

Prattis, P. L. "An Open Letter to Dr. Joseph Goebbels, German Minister of National Enlightenment and Propaganda." *New Pittsburg Courier*. Mar. 4, 1939. Newspapers.com
This open letter, "sent" to the Nazi propaganda minister in charge of persecuting the Jews, informing him of the Marian Anderson situation, provides a great deal of historical context for the discussions surrounding race and discrimination at that time in America. This ties in additionally with the letter referenced in our performance, accusing the DAR of supporting Nazi philosophy, showing the global implications of their actions.

Richards, Anna. Letter to Robert (President General). March 5, 1939. DAR Subject Files, Anderson, Marian. DAR Archives, Daughters of the American Revolution, Washington, DC.
https://www.dar.org/sites/default/files/25_SCR_DAR%20Subject%20Files_Anderson%2C%20Marian_March%205%2C%201939%20Letter%20from%20DAR%20member%20Anna%20Richards%20to%20PG%20Robert.jpg.
This letter shows the multiple perspectives that individual DAR members had regarding the decision not to allow Marian Anderson to perform. Although not directly quoted in our performance, this letter still proved to be key to our understanding of the multifaceted way that DAR members showed their support for Anderson.

Roberts, Sallie Hason, *Letter from Mrs. Henry M. Robert, Jr., president general of the DAR, responding to Mrs. Roosevelt's resignation.* Letter. Accessed February 11, 2026.
We used this letter for Mrs. Robert's response to Eleanor Roosevelt in the performance. This letter helped us understand the official stance of the DAR leadership and their justification for their organization's policies.

Roosevelt, Eleanor. *Letter from Eleanor Roosevelt to the President General of the DAR.* Letter. From Archive.org. https://www.archives.gov/exhibits/american_originals/eleanor.html (accessed February 16, 2022).
This letter was used in Eleanor Roosevelt's response to the DAR preventing Marian Anderson from performing. This letter clarified Eleanor Roosevelt's personal conviction and her decision to stand against the DAR.

Roosevelt, Eleanor. "My Day." *Washington Daily News*, February 27, 1939. DAR Subject Files, Anderson, Marian. DAR Archives, Daughters of the American Revolution, Washington, DC.
https://www.dar.org/sites/default/files/12bb%20SCR_DAR%20Subject%20Files_Anders

on%2C%20Marian_February%2027%2C%201939%20Eleanor%20Roosevelt%20My%20Day%20column%20in%20the%20Washington%20Daily%20News_0.jpg.
This is the newspaper column that Eleanor Roosevelt (famously her My Day column) wrote, where she expressed public disapproval for the actions of the Daughters of the American Revolution regarding Marian Anderson. This primary source was the cause for the widespread backlash that the DAR received as it publicized the event beyond the confines of local news. We quoted this source directly in our performance.

Roosevelt, Eleanor, *Telegram to Treasurer of Marian Anderson Citizens Committee*, reported in The New York Times, February 27, 1939
This telegram demonstrated Eleanor Roosevelt's transition from a private protest to a more public advocacy. We used this source to showcase Roosevelt's first public action of disapproval against the DAR.

Smith, Isadora. "World Fair Throng Acclaims Marian Anderson: Music Hall Unable to Hold Huge Crowd in Record Turnout." [Newspaper unknown], June 1, 1939. Marian Anderson Papers, box 410, item 1. Colenda Digital Repositories, Penn Libraries, Philadelphia, PA. https://colenda.library.upenn.edu/catalog/81431-p3hm52n3j
This page from one of Marian Anderson's scrapbooks details Anderson's popularity on the American stage. We used this page as a way to gauge how the average American would react to hearing about an opportunity to see Ms. Anderson, thus helping us to better write the character of Susan (someone supposed to represent the American public).

Sr. Scott B. Thompson. "Laurens County African American History: THE FIRST PUBLIC SPEECH of DR. MARTIN LUTHER KING, JR." *Laurens County African American History*, 26 July 2009, laurenscountyafricanamericanhistory.blogspot.com/2009/07/first-public-speech-of-dr-martin-luther.html.
This speech, as recited in our performance, is Martin Luther King's prize-winning oratorical essay in which he discusses the story of Marian Anderson and her struggle against the DAR.

U.S. Continental Congress. Declaration of Independence. July 4, 1776. National Archives. https://www.archives.gov/founding-docs/declaration.
We used this founding document to show the contradicting ideas of the DAR when defending their white performers-only policy. In following the ideals of racial purity, they neglected the actual founding statement that all men are created equal (this was quoted in our performance).

Washington Post. "Marian Anderson's Recital Draws 75,000, Many Notables, to Lincoln

Memorial." April 10, 1939. DAR Archives, Daughters of the American Revolution, Washington, DC. https://www.dar.org/sites/default/files/washpostApril10.pdf.
This is the newspaper that was published the day after Marian Anderson's performance. It shows the immediate national significance that her performance gained (short-term impact).

Whitney, May. Letter to Robert (President General). March 14, 1939. DAR Subject Files, Anderson, Marian. DAR Archives, Daughters of the American Revolution, Washington, DC.
https://www.dar.org/sites/default/files/24_SCR_DAR%20Subject%20Files_Anderson%2C%20Marian_March%2014%2C%201939%20Letter%20from%20DAR%20member%20May%20Whitney%20to%20PG%20Robert.jpg.
This is one of the letters of support that was sent to the DAR after news of Marian Anderson's rejection from Constitution Hall reached national headlines. This letter, as quoted in our performance, showcases that the DAR still had the loyalty of its members.

Secondary Sources:

"A Life Well Sung: With Eleanor Roosevelt at Her Side, and a Young MLK in The Audience, Singer Marian Anderson Inspired Change with an Historic Concert - Grid Magazine." Grid Magazine. April 30, 2019. https://gridphilly.com/blog-home/2019/04/30/a-life-well-sung-with-eleanor-roosevelt-at-her-side-and-a-young-mlk-in-the-audience-singer-marian-anderson-inspired-change-with-an-historic-concert/.

This article explores the intersectional impact of the 1939 performance, specifically noting the presence of a young Martin Luther King Jr. in the audience and the direct support of Eleanor Roosevelt. We used this source to illustrate the concert's role as a bridge between the early struggles against segregation and the later Civil Rights Movement, emphasizing how the event "inspired change" both politically and individually.

Ancheta, Bianca. 2021. "Modesto Symphony Orchestra." Modesto Symphony Orchestra. February 4, 2021. https://www.modestosymphony.org/offstage-blog/msohistory-mariananderson.

This article details Marian Anderson's 1941 performance, illustrating the trajectory of her career and her continued influence across the United States following her national breakthrough. We saw this as the long-term impact of the 1939 concert on her professional touring life and her reception by diverse American audiences.

Blevins, Emeline. "History of the Daughters of the American Revolution." *Frances Keyes and the Daughters of the American Revolution* (blog). University of Richmond. Accessed April 29, 2024. https://blog.richmond.edu/keyes/history-of-the-dar/.

This source examines the organizational evolution and social influence of the DAR, specifically focusing on its public image and leadership during the early 20th century. We used this to gain an academic perspective on the internal culture of the organization, providing context for the rigid policies that led to their controversial decision in 1939.

"Capital Connections | Smithsonian Institution." *Capital Connections*. Accessed April 29, 2026. https://www.si.edu/spotlight/marian-anderson/dc-connections.

This article from the Smithsonian Museum of American History highlights the specific geographical and institutional links Marian Anderson had within Washington, D.C., including the Howard University sponsorship of the event. We utilized this source to map out the local landscape of segregation and the network of activists who helped secure the Lincoln Memorial as a protest venue.

"Constitution Hall History." Daughters of the American Revolution. Accessed April 29, 2026. https://www.dar.org/events/constitution-hall/constitution-hall-history.
This official history outlines the origins of the DAR's headquarters and the organization's policies regarding performers during the 1930s. We used this source to provide the perspective on the initial refusal to host Anderson, which served as the primary catalyst for the April 1939 concert.

"Denyce Graves and Others Discuss Marian Anderson's Legacy." PBS American Masters. February 4, 2022. https://www.pbs.org/wnet/americanmasters/denyce-graves-and-others-discuss-marian-andersons-legacy/22870/.
This resource features contemporary perspectives from leading opera figures, including Denyce Graves, on the enduring impact of Anderson's career. We used this source to connect the historical events of 1939 to the broader trajectory of Black representation in classical music, demonstrating how Marian Anderson greatly dismantled systemic barriers for future generations of performers.

"Eleanor Roosevelt and Marian Anderson - FDR Presidential Library & Museum." 2009. Fdrlibrary.org. 2009. https://www.fdrlibrary.org/anderson.
We used this source in the mention of Secretary Harold Ickes and his effort in acquiring a performance for Marian Anderson.

"Eleanor Roosevelt and Marian Anderson." Franklin D. Roosevelt Presidential Library and Museum. Accessed April 29, 2026. https://www.fdrlibrary.org/anderson.1.
This is a great general explanation of the weeks-long effort by Eleanor Roosevelt to lobby the DAR to allow Marian Anderson to perform. It also mentions other famous black artists denied the right to perform there, like Paul Robeson.

"ER and the Marian Anderson Concert | Eleanor Roosevelt Papers Project | the George Washington University." 2019. Eleanor Roosevelt Papers Project. 2019. https://erpapers.columbian.gwu.edu/er-and-marian-anderson-concert.
This article was used near the end of the performance during the mention of the Spingarn Medal. It helped us understand the legacy of Marian Anderson's performance.

"Her Song and Her Spirit Could Not Be Silenced." n.d. National Museum of African American History and Culture. https://nmaahc.si.edu/explore/stories/her-song-and-her-spirit-could-not-be-silenced.
This article provides context as well as basic knowledge of the events that occurred before Marian Anderson's performance.

"How Racism Affected Marian Anderson's Vocal Classification." PBS American Masters. February 4, 2022. https://www.pbs.org/wnet/americanmasters/how-racism-affected-marian-andersons-vocal-classification-4l/20032/.
This article examines how Anderson's rare contralto range was often misunderstood or limited by the biases of the Western classical establishment. We utilized this source to analyze the cultural obstacles Anderson faced beyond venue restrictions, highlighting the "reforms" required to acknowledge Black vocal excellence on its own terms.

"How Soprano Marian Anderson Found an Ally in Eleanor Roosevelt." 2024. Classical Music. December 9, 2024. https://www.classical-music.com/features/artists/marian-anderson-eleanor-roosevelt.
This article describes the events of Marian Anderson's performance through a symbolic lens, emphasizing how the concert transformed the Lincoln Memorial into a site of national protest and a powerful stage for the early Civil Rights Movement.

KaraokeOnVEVO, "Patriotic - America (My Country 'Tis Of Thee) (Karaoke)". 1:49. January 24, 2022. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nq0ddfnIG9E
This YouTube video was used as the accompaniment for the song Marian Anderson sang: My Country 'Tis of Thee to accurately portray her performance at the Lincoln Memorial.

"Marian Anderson." Home of Franklin D. Roosevelt National Historic Site. National Park Service. January 15, 2024. https://www.nps.gov/hofr/learn/historyculture/marian-anderson.htm.
This article talks about the long-term impacts that Marian Anderson's performance had on the ideas of racial segregation that were upheld by the DAR and how America as a whole reformed its ideas on black performers.

"Marian Anderson in Europe." *Rosenwald* (film website). Ciesla Foundation.Accessed April 29, 2026. https://rosenwaldfilm.org/marian-anderson-in-europe/.
This article chronicles Anderson's professional successes abroad and the financial support she received from the Rosenwald Fund to study in Europe. We included this to establish the irony of her global status as a celebrated "Voice of the Century" while she still faced discrimination in her home country.

"Marian Anderson Papers, 1900–1993." Kislak Center for Special Collections, Rare Books and Manuscripts. University of Pennsylvania Libraries. Accessed April 29, 2026. https://findingaids.library.upenn.edu/records/UPENN_RBML_PUSP.MS.COLL.200.
This finding aid provides a comprehensive inventory of Anderson's personal correspondence, concert programs, and professional documents held within her archives.

We used this resource to locate primary evidence of her private reactions to the 1939 concert and to verify the timeline of her career milestones.

Miller, Cait. “Marian Anderson’s #LincolnMemorialMoment | in the Muse.” The Library of Congress. May 12, 2022. https://blogs.loc.gov/music/2022/05/marian-andersons-lincoln-memorial-moment/. This article explores the visual and musical legacy of the concert, utilizing primary source materials from the Library’s music division to analyze the specific repertoire performed. We used this source to examine how the event was curated as a deliberate "moment" of cultural diplomacy and to understand the specific impact of her song choices on the audience.

Morris, Aldon D. 1984. The Origins of the Civil Rights Movement: Black Communities Organizing for Change. New York: Free Press.
This book explores the history of the Civil Rights movement in American history, starting from the Freedom Riders and the NAACP. We used this source to further explore the context in which Marian Anderson performed by exploring the role of the NAACP in the movement for civil rights.

National Park Service. “Constitution Hall.” Accessed April 29, 2026. https://www.nps.gov/places/constitution-hall.htm.
This article discusses the significance of Constitution Hall as a national landmark in Washington, D.C. This piece of information explains why the idea of Marian Anderson performing there was so significant for the advancement of black individuals culturally.

O'Dell, Cary. "NBC Radio Coverage of Marian Anderson’s Recital at the Lincoln Memorial (April 9, 1939)". National Registry, 2008. https://www.loc.gov/static/programs/national-recording-preservation-board/documents/MarianAndersonLincolnMem.pdf
This essay provides a detailed historical overview of the radio broadcast that brought Anderson’s performance to millions of listeners across the country. We used this source to understand the technical and cultural significance of the live recording, which preserved the concert as a landmark moment in media history.

Smith-Soto, David. 2013. “When Dr. King Spoke in Front of the Lincoln Memorial 50 Years Ago, I Listened.” Borderzine. August 30, 2013. https://borderzine.com/2013/08/when-dr-king-spoke-in-front-of-the-lincoln-memorial-50-years-ago-i-listened/.
This account reflects on the 1963 March on Washington and the powerful atmosphere of protest and oratory at the Lincoln Memorial. We used this source to draw a thematic

connection between the 1939 concert and the later Civil Rights Movement, showing how Anderson's performance established the Memorial as a site for racial justice.

Stamberg, Susan. 2014. "Denied a Stage, She Sang for a Nation." NPR.org. April 9, 2014. https://www.npr.org/2014/04/09/298760473/denied-a-stage-she-sang-for-a-nation. This news article goes over the basic events that led up to Marian Anderson's performance on the steps of the Lincoln Memorial. It provides many perspectives in the context that led up to her performance (ie, news backlash towards the DAR), and also discusses the major impacts that Anderson would have on many young black performers.